

Jesus Gathers Disciples



3-Minute Retreat

As you prepare the session, pause and pay attention to your breathing. Take three deep breaths and reflect on the love you receive from God the Father, Jesus the Son, and the Holy Spirit.

Luke 5:10

Jesus said to Simon, "Do not be afraid; from now on you will be catching men."

Reflection

Following an unsuccessful night of fishing, Simon, whom we know as Peter, meets Jesus, and his life is changed forever. We too can find our lives transformed as we listen to and act on the words of Jesus. Like Peter, we may prefer the familiar and be fearful when life is not what we expect. Jesus assures us that when we respond to his call, our commitment will bear fruit as God intends. Joining in Jesus' mission, we follow the well-traveled path of the Apostles and earliest disciples.

Question

What do I find challenging about my mission and call to follow Jesus as a catechist?



Prayer

Pray, using these words or your own.

Jesus, transform my life with your acceptance and love so that I may do your work in the world without fear.

Working and Sharing Your Faith in Session 8

Consider how Scripture and Tradition can deepen your understanding of the session content.

Scripture

John 1:35–39 tells how Jesus gathered his first disciples.

Luke 5:1–11 tells us that Simon, whom Jesus names Peter, is to be a fisher of men.

Tradition

As with our understanding of the Kingdom of God, our contemporary understanding of the Church's mission is reflected in the documents of the Second Vatican Council. The Council tells us that we have been sent by Christ to reveal and to communicate the love of God to all people and all nations and to serve the Kingdom of God everywhere for the glory of God the Father. The goal is to bring all people to share in Christ's saving redemption. The Church proclaims the coming of the kingdom through its preaching but also through its very being, for the Church is the initial budding forth of the kingdom.

Catholic Social Teaching

The integrated Catholic social teaching theme in this session is **Call to Family, Community, and Participation**. See page 43b for an explanation of this theme.

Window on the Catechism

The mission of the Church in the world is summarized in CCC 2044–2046.

General Directory for Catechesis

The nature of discipleship is examined in GDC 15 and 16.

1-Hour Session Planner

SESSION 8 Jesus Gathers Disciples

Session Theme: *Jesus invites his followers to enter the Kingdom of God.*

Before This Session

- ▶ You may wish to obtain a copy of *Being Disciples of Jesus* published by Loyola Press. It provides a look at the first 12 disciples.
- ▶ Bookmark your Bible to John 1:35–39 and Luke 5:1–11. Place the open Bible in your Prayer Center.
- ▶ Read the Guide for this session, choose any additional multimedia content or If Time Allows activities that you might have time to complete, and gather the listed materials.

Scripture in Session 8

- ▶ John 1:35–39
- ▶ Luke 5:1–11

Prayer in Session 8

The opening and closing prayers relate to the focus of this session—following Jesus. The Reflect step is a short guided reflection on the story of Jesus calling Peter to follow him. The guided reflection provides children with an opportunity to pray in silence, relating the main focus to their personal prayers.

STEPS		1 HOUR
ENGAGE	Jesus Gathers Disciples PAGE 63	
EXPLORE	Jesus Calls Peter PAGES 64–65 Art Print 8: Acts of the Apostles ART PRINT AND PRINT BACK Proclaiming the Kingdom PAGE 66	
REFLECT	Prayer: Next to the Lake PAGE 67 We Do This Together PAGE 68	
RESPOND	Living My Faith PAGE 69	
AT HOME Scripture reading, discussion, and activity for families PAGE 70		

Materials

REQUIRED

- ▶ Bible
- ▶ Device with internet access
- ▶ Art Print 8: *Acts of the Apostles* (easel)
- ▶ Fishing pole or fishing lure
- ▶ Recorded Guided Reflection: “Jesus Calls Peter”
- ▶ Music: “Here I Am, God”
- ▶ Art supplies
- ▶ Writing supplies

OPTIONAL

- ▶ Device with QR code reader
- ▶ Scripture BLM 8
- ▶ Activity BLM 8
- ▶ Broom handle, string, magnet, cardstock, paper clips
- ▶ Scripture Prayer Service BLM 8
- ▶ Netting
- ▶ Assessment: Session 8 www.findinggod.com

Jesus Gathers Disciples

SESSION
8



GOD'S WORD

Read and listen to
John 1:35–39.

The disciples learned that Jesus was the Son of God. They went to him. They wanted to be with him and learn from him. Jesus welcomed them. He said, "Come and you will see." They lived and worked with Jesus to serve the Kingdom of God.

Jesus welcomes us into the Kingdom of God. We can serve him by being a good friend to others. We can be helpful to our classmates. We can be kind to our relatives. We can be friendly to people we meet. When we aren't sure what to do, we can pray to Jesus for help in seeing the way.



Jesus teaching the disciples,
stained glass, Sacred Heart
Church, St. Paul, Minnesota



Prayer

Loving Jesus, show me how to be your friend so that I can be a friend to others.

63

UNDERSTANDING SCRIPTURE

Rather than minister alone, Jesus gathered disciples to help him bring people to God. In this passage, the first two disciples [according to John's account] join Jesus. If we read on in the passage, we see Jesus calling three additional disciples. In other Gospels' accounts, Jesus calls fishermen working by the Sea of Galilee as his first disciples, as children will read on the next two pages. As disciples ourselves, we all respond to Jesus' simple invitation, "Come and you will see."

IF TIME ALLOWS

Scripture BLM: John 1:35–39

Have children complete Scripture BLM 8 to gain a better understanding of the passage.



SESSION 8

Discuss how Jesus gathered the disciples.

Tell the story of how Jesus chose Peter to follow him.

Explore why Jesus needed apostles and disciples to help him.

Discuss reasons why we need to work together to serve the kingdom.

Define *Gospel* and *mission*.

1 Open Your Heart

Invite children to quiet themselves and prepare to hear sacred Scripture.

2 Proclaim God's Word

Take the Bible from the Prayer Center. Read John 1:35–39. Then say: **The Gospel of the Lord.** Invite children to respond *Praise to you, Lord Jesus Christ.*

3 The Word Alive

Ask: **If you could ask a famous athlete to teach you his or her skills, who would you ask?** (accept reasonable responses) Say: **We like to learn from the best.** Read the paragraphs aloud. Ask: **Why do you think the disciples followed Jesus?** (They knew he was the best to teach them about God.)



Prayer

Say: **Let's ask Jesus to help us be a good friend to him and to one another.** Pray aloud the prayer. Then pause for additional reflection. Conclude the prayer by praying *Amen.*



If appropriate and feasible, have children scan the code on page 63.

Jesus Calls Peter

The **Gospels** are parts of the Bible that tell the Good News of Jesus' life. In the Gospel of Luke, we learn how Jesus called Peter to follow him. Before he followed Jesus, Peter was called "Simon."

While the crowd was pressing in on Jesus and listening to the word of God, he was standing by the Lake of Gennesaret. He saw two boats there alongside the lake; the fishermen had disembarked and were washing their nets. Getting into one of the boats, the one belonging to Simon, he asked him to put out a short distance from the shore. Then he sat down and taught the crowds from the boat. After he had finished speaking, he said to Simon, "Put out into deep water and lower your nets for a catch." Simon said in reply, "Master, we have worked hard all night and have caught nothing, but at your command I will lower the nets."

Luke 5:1-5

Would you trust Jesus as Peter did?



IF TIME ALLOWS

Activity BLM: Fishing for Good Deeds

Have children complete Activity BLM 8 to "fish" for good deeds they can do for others. Provide a basket for the children's fish.



Role-Play the Story

Invite volunteers to role-play the story of Jesus and Peter. Give children time to reread the story, thinking about how each character would act and look. Choose volunteers to play Jesus, Peter, and the other fishermen, and to read as narrators. Have the narrators read aloud slowly and with expression while the actors pantomime the actions.

1 Begin

Show children a fishing lure or pole. Ask if anyone has ever used one of these and invite a volunteer to tell about a fishing experience. Say: **Two of Jesus' disciples were fishing when he called to them. The disciples fished with nets rather than fishing rods, because they made their living by fishing.**

2 Connect



Read aloud the heading. Say: **Peter was a fisherman who was called "Simon" before he followed Jesus. Fishermen like Peter threw nets into the water to catch fish. This is how they earned a living. We will learn how Jesus called this man named Simon, who became Peter, to follow him.** Read aloud the first paragraph. Have children look up the word *Gospel* in the Glossary. Ask: **Where have you heard that word?** (at Mass, when the priest introduces the third reading in the Liturgy of the Word, when he reads about Jesus' teachings, life, and deeds) Show children the Gospels in your Bible.

Invite volunteers to read aloud the Scripture story on page 64. Read and discuss the question below it before reading the story's conclusion on page 65.

Ask: **Why did Peter lower the nets if he didn't think he could catch anything?** (He trusted Jesus.)

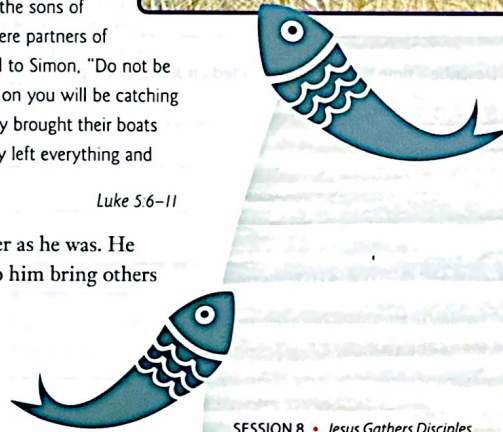
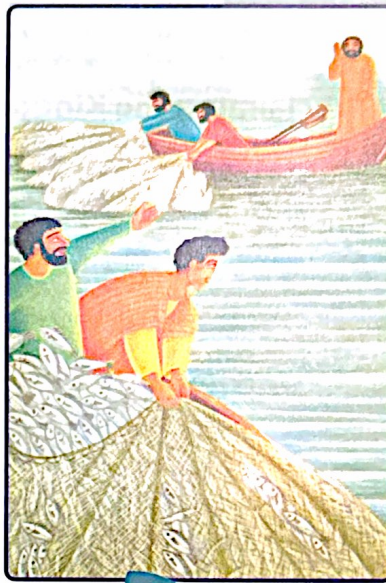
Peter Answers Jesus' Call

Peter knew he could do more with Jesus' help than by himself.

When they had done this, they caught a great number of fish and their nets were tearing. They signaled to their partners in the other boat to come to help them. They came and filled both boats so that they were in danger of sinking. When Simon Peter saw this, he fell at the knees of Jesus and said, "Depart from me, Lord, for I am a sinful man." For astonishment at the catch of fish they had made seized him and all those with him, and likewise James and John, the sons of Zebedee, who were partners of Simon. Jesus said to Simon, "Do not be afraid; from now on you will be catching men." When they brought their boats to the shore, they left everything and followed him.

Luke 5:6-11

Jesus accepted Peter as he was. He called Peter to help him bring others to God.



SESSION 8 • Jesus Gathers Disciples 65

Ask: **Why did Peter tell Jesus to leave him?** (He felt he was not good enough to be a follower of Jesus.) **What did Jesus mean when he said they would be catching men?** (They would bring more people to follow Jesus, just as they caught more fish when they lowered their nets again.) **What does it mean that Jesus accepted Peter as he was?** (Jesus knew Peter was sinful but that he would become a better person by following Jesus.) Say: **Jesus knows we aren't perfect. He accepts us as we are. He wants us to follow him.**



After reading aloud the second part of the Scripture story, invite children to imagine the

scene as they listen to "Jesus Calls Peter," a dramatized recording of it.

Say: **In the early years of the Church, Christians used the shape of a fish as a symbol of their faith.** Have children make fish out of 12-inch craft stems. Bend the stem in half and twist it together near the end to make a tail. Pull apart the middle to resemble a fish.

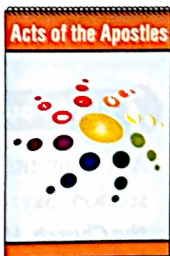


Say: **I am going to play a song we can sing to tell God we will answer his call. The words remind us of how the**

Apostles felt when they met Jesus and decided to serve him. Play for children the song "Here I Am, God." Ask: **How does this song encourage us to follow Jesus?** (Answers will vary.)

3 Close

Use the following page and the Art Print easel to teach Art Print 8: *Acts of the Apostles*.



IF TIME ALLOWS

Fishermen Called by Jesus

Give children sheets of different-colored construction paper and seven pieces of twine about 10 inches long. Have each child cut three or four fish shapes. With their twine, have children make nets by laying out three pieces of twine up and down and four pieces across. Have children place dots of glue where the pieces of twine cross. Have children trade fish with one another so that each child has different-colored fish, then glue the fish to their nets.

FOR THE CATECHIST



READ an article about Saint Peter.



1 Begin

Display the Art Print easel open to Art Print 8. Briefly introduce and discuss the artwork, using information from About the Artist and Art•i•facts. Ask: **What do you think is happening in this artwork?** (Peter and the other Apostles are preaching to a group of people.)

2 Connect

Read aloud the introduction and discuss the question. Invite a volunteer to read aloud the first paragraph of Proclaiming the Kingdom. Have children look up *mission* in the Glossary. Ask: **What does the word mission mean?** (the work of Jesus carried on by his followers) **What does proclaim mean?** (to announce publicly) **Whom did Jesus choose to proclaim God's kingdom?** (Peter, the other Apostles, and the disciples) Read aloud the next paragraph. Say: **We can all be disciples by proclaiming God's message and doing good deeds.**

ACTIVITY Read aloud Lean on Me. Give children time to write their descriptions. Then invite them to share their responses.

3 Close

Invite children to reflect on the artwork and to pray a silent prayer asking Jesus to help his followers answer his call.

? Did You Know?

Ask a volunteer to read aloud this section. Say: **The pope is the head of the Church. He follows in Saint Peter's footsteps.**

Art Print 8 shows the apostles and the disciples spreading God's Word. What is one way that you serve Jesus?

Proclaiming the Kingdom

Jesus knew he needed help spreading God's Word. He chose Peter, the other Apostles, and the followers called disciples to help with his work. Jesus' Apostles and disciples accepted the **mission** that Jesus gave them to proclaim God's kingdom.

Jesus depended on his friends to help him do the job God gave him. We can work together with our friends to help answer Jesus' call.



ACTIVITY: Lean on Me

Think of jobs you have at school or home.

Describe a time when you depended on a friend for help.

Answers will vary.

Describe a time when you depended on Jesus for help.

Answers will vary.

? Did You Know?

Jesus chose 12 Apostles to lead the Church. The pope and bishops of the Catholic Church continue the Apostles' mission today.

IF TIME ALLOWS

Art Studio: Jesus' Friends

Distribute drawing paper and art supplies. Have children draw a picture of a present-day disciple. Explain that they may choose to draw a picture of a priest, teacher, catechist, or godparent, or they might draw themselves since they are also followers of Jesus Christ. Have them write a sentence or two explaining how the person in the picture is a disciple.

Using the Art Print

For additional activities and prayer opportunities, see the Art Print back.

Next to the Lake

Imagine you are standing with the people on the shore of the lake watching Jesus and Peter. In the quiet of your heart, pray the imaginative prayer below.



Prayer

The sun has just risen. There are mountains in the distance. What colors do you see in the sky? What are some of the smells along the shore? Listen as Jesus talks to the people from the boat. What might he be saying?

Now imagine it is a little later and the boats are back onshore. Watch Peter and the others leave everything and follow Jesus.

Now imagine that Jesus, Peter, and the others are coming toward you! Picture yourself walking through the sand in your bare feet to meet Jesus. What does he say to you? What is your answer?



SESSION 8 • Jesus Gathers Disciples 67

REFLECT



Children's Prayer

Prepare Pray the prayer on page 67 in advance to become familiar with it.



Prayer



Invite children to be still. Point to the picture. Tell them you will play the song "Here I Am, God"

to help them relax and concentrate on what they've learned today. Say: **As you listen to the song, think about Jesus and Peter and the importance of working with friends.**

After listening, suggest that the words might be similar to what Peter said to Jesus at the lake. Turn off the music.

Say: **Peter listened when Jesus called him. Jesus is calling us too. Let's spend time with Jesus and listen for his call.**

Read aloud the heading and the two sentences under it. Tell children that you will read the reflection while they imagine the scenes. Ask them to quiet their bodies, minds, and hearts, and close their eyes. Read aloud the reflection, pausing after each sentence to give children time to imagine the scene and silently answer the questions.

Tell children you will give them a few moments to be alone with Jesus. Pause; then pray *Amen*. Say: **Now that we have told Jesus we will follow him, let's review some ways of following Jesus in our daily lives.**

IF TIME ALLOWS

With Jesus on the Shore

To extend the reflection, give children paper and crayons. Have them draw the scene they imagined. Encourage children to show themselves in the picture, perhaps talking to Jesus.

Scripture Prayer Service BLM: John 1:35–39

For an optional Prayer Service focused on this session's opening Scripture passage, refer to Scripture Prayer Service BLM 8.



COACHING CHILDREN TO PRAY

Tell children that the reflection above is an opportunity to use their imaginations in prayer. Explain that they can use their senses—sight, smell, hearing, and touch—as they imagine the scene.



If appropriate and feasible, have children scan the code on page 67.

1 Begin

Read aloud the heading and talk about the idea of working together. Ask children how they work together as a group, such as cooperating on projects or by cleaning up after completing an activity. Say: **Jesus knew he could accomplish more with the help of his friends, the Apostles.**

2 Connect

Ask a volunteer to read aloud the paragraph. Ask: **Can you tell about a time when you recently worked in a group to complete a task?** (Possible answers: working with friends at a parish function; working in a neighborhood cleanup crew)

ACTIVITY Read aloud Plan a Task. Give children time to complete their labels. Then encourage them to share how they organized the task. Discuss how working together helps us help Jesus with his work.

✝ **Family and Community**

3 Close

Direct children's attention to the feature on page 68.

✝ Reading God's Word

Ask a volunteer to read aloud this passage. Ask: **Why do you think Jesus sent people to the towns he planned to visit?** (so the people in the town would know to expect him) **Why did Jesus need so many helpers?** (Many people working together can accomplish a lot.)

We Do This Together

Sometimes it takes many people working together to complete a task. Jesus' Apostles learned to work together when they went out to proclaim God's Word.

ACTIVITY: Plan a Task

Suppose your class just finished an art project. Think of different jobs that could be done to clean up. Complete the labels with four people's names and what each one's job will be.



Clean Up After Class

Name: _____

Job: _____

Name: _____

Job: _____

Name: _____

Job: _____

Name: _____

Job: _____



Reading God's Word

[Jesus] appointed seventy-two others whom he sent ahead of him in pairs to every town and place he intended to visit.

Luke 10:1

IF TIME ALLOWS

Qualities of a Friend

Discuss what makes someone a good friend. Distribute drawing paper and crayons. Invite children to draw pictures of themselves with friends. Say: **Just as we are friends with others, we are also friends with Jesus.**

INCLUSION

Autism Spectrum

It can be challenging for children with autism to make friends. Keep this in mind as you ask children to complete the activity above, "Qualities of a Friend." To help children with the discussion of what makes a good friend, consider providing the child with a list of characteristics from which they can choose.

Living My Faith

Faith Summary

Jesus chose the Apostles and sent them on a mission to preach the Word of God. He also chose disciples to help him. Jesus wants us to proclaim the Kingdom of God.



Words I Learned

Gospel mission

Ways of Being Like Jesus

Jesus chose certain people to help him.
When you work in a group, listen to others and respect their ideas.



Prayer

Dear Jesus, like Peter, I trust you to guide my life. Thank you for calling me to follow you.

ACTIVITY: Disciples in Action

Write a poem about Jesus.

Think of words and images that describe Jesus. Then complete each line.

Jesus is Answers will vary.

Jesus is _____

Jesus is _____

Jesus is _____



SESSION 8 Jesus Gathers Disciples 69

IF TIME ALLOWS

Service: Share the Good News

First, consult your catechetical leader. Then, to build community in your program, arrange a time when your children can visit another class to act out the story of Jesus choosing Peter. Have children practice their skit before the visit. They can carry netting to emphasize Jesus' Apostles becoming "fishers" of men.



Family and Community



ACCESS an Interactive Session Review.



Begin

Faith Summary Read aloud the paragraph. Review ways we can proclaim the Kingdom of God. Ask: **What did we learn from Jesus about working together?** (He worked with the Apostles and disciples to proclaim the Kingdom of God.)



Connect

Words I Learned Review the meaning of each word. Have children refer to the Glossary if necessary. For *Gospel*, point out Luke's Gospel in the Bible. Then ask: **What is your mission as a follower of Jesus?** (to serve God's kingdom)

Ways of Being Like Jesus Invite a volunteer to read the paragraph. Discuss how being respectful to our peers serves the Kingdom of God. Say: **Let's make it our mission to work lovingly with others in order to serve the Kingdom of God.**



Family and Community

ACTIVITY Read aloud the directions. Guide children to use specific words and short phrases like "Lord" or "my teacher" instead of generic adjectives like "awesome." Invite volunteers to share their responses.



Prayer

Say: **Let's thank Jesus for his guidance.** Ask children to sit quietly with their hands folded and pray together the prayer. Pause for a moment and then lead children in praying the Sign of the Cross.

3 Go in Peace

Invite children to share this tear-out page with their families. To close this session, say: **Let us remember to be good friends to one another just as Jesus was to the Apostles.**

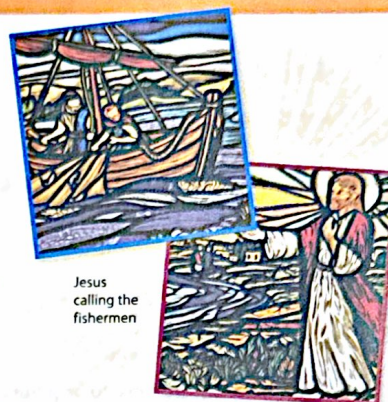
With My Family

Scripture Together

Jesus chose 12 of his disciples, or followers, to help him share his message. These 12 were the Apostles. The word *apostle* means "one sent forth."

As a family, read **Mark 1:16–20** to see how Jesus called his first disciples. When you have finished, discuss the Scripture. Use the questions below to guide you:

- What did Jesus ask the fishermen to do?
- What would you be experiencing if you were Simon (Peter), Andrew, James, or John?
- What might you need to leave behind at one time or another to follow Jesus?



Jesus calling the fishermen



Family Prayer

Pray together:
Dear God, help us answer Jesus' call to follow him every day. Amen.

Faith on the Go

Ask one another: *If you could help anyone, whom would you help? How would you help the person?*

ACTIVITY: Family Fun Night

Play a game or do another fun activity that requires you to help one another.



ASSESSMENT

Session Assessment Option

A session assessment can be found at www.findinggod.com.

PLAN AHEAD: Get Ready for Session 9

Consult the catechist preparation pages to prepare for Session 9 and determine any materials you will need.

Living as God's Children



3-Minute Retreat

Before preparing the session, pause and breathe deeply several times. Set aside distractions. Know that God is your Father. He loves you. He watches over you. He is present to you.

Philippians 1:9–11

And this is my prayer: that your love may increase ever more and more in knowledge and every kind of perception, to discern what is of value, so that you may be pure and blameless for the day of Christ.

Reflection

In this letter, Saint Paul expresses his great love and hopeful prayer for the growing community of faith. Families are the first community of faith. In unity with the Holy Spirit, they can be a fruitful source of love, peace, and justice. Our families teach us how to share, how to love, how to be fair, and how to serve others. We can join in the prayer of Paul as we think of the families we know. In our own family, we have a wonderful opportunity to participate in the work of the Holy Spirit—to serve the Kingdom of God on earth.

Question

How can I help children view other families' struggles with eyes of love rather than judgment?



Prayer

Speak to God, using these words or others that come to mind.

Lord Jesus Christ, be with my family and the families in our parish so that we may grow in understanding of one another. Help us know what is of value, knowing that what is of value brings us, together, to you.

Knowing and Sharing Your Faith in Session 23

Consider how Scripture and Tradition can deepen your understanding of the session content.

Scripture

Luke 2:41–52 tells the story of Joseph and Mary finding Jesus discussing Scripture with Jewish elders.

Galatians 6:2 teaches us that all are asked to bear one another's burdens.

Philippians 1:3–11 tells how Paul prays that the Christian community will increase in love and knowledge for the glory of God.

Tradition

Our entire religious Tradition is centered on the importance of healthy relationships. In the Old Testament, we hear the divine statement that it is not good for us to be alone. God intervened in human history to form Abraham's descendants into one people. Jesus comes in fulfillment of the Scriptures as a member of a family. He teaches his followers that God is their Father, and he makes it clear to them that they are brothers and sisters. Jesus sought to teach his disciples to form healthy communities.

Catholic Social Teaching

The integrated Catholic social teaching themes in this session are **Life and Dignity of the Human Person** and **Option for the Poor and Vulnerable**. See page 169b for an explanation of these themes.

Window on the Catechism

The "communal character of the human vocation" is discussed in CCC 1878–1885. The concept of love of neighbor is addressed in CCC 2196.

General Directory for Catechesis

The task of catechizing people into a community of faith is explored in GDC 220.

1-Hour Session Planner

SESSION 23 *Living as God's Children*

Session Theme: *Jesus helps us love and respect one another.*

Before This Session

- ▶ Bookmark your Bible to Luke 2:41–52, Philippians 1:3–11, and Galatians 6:2. Place the Bible open to one of these passages in your Prayer Center.
- ▶ Read the Guide for this session, choose any additional multimedia content or If Time Allows activities that you might have time to complete, and gather the listed materials.

Scripture in Session 23

- ▶ Luke 2:41–52
- ▶ Galatians 6:2
- ▶ Philippians 1:3–11

Prayer in Session 23

In this session, children pray prayers of petition and gratitude for Jesus' guidance and love. Session 23 includes a recorded guided reflection, "Hold Them in Your Heart."

STEPS		1 HOUR
ENGAGE	Living as God's Children PAGE 189	
EXPLORE	The Domestic Church PAGE 190 Saint Louise de Marillac PAGE 191 Art Print 23: Saint Paul ART PRINT AND PRINT BACK Saint Paul's Joy PAGE 192	
REFLECT	Prayer: A Prayer for Family Members PAGE 193 Family Cooperation PAGE 194	
RESPOND	Living My Faith PAGE 195	
AT HOME Scripture reading, discussion, and activity for families PAGE 196		

Materials**REQUIRED**

- ▶ Bible
- ▶ Device with QR code reader and internet access
- ▶ An example of a greeting card
- ▶ Art Print 23: *Saint Paul* (easel)
- ▶ Recorded Guided Reflection: "Hold Them in Your Heart"
- ▶ Art supplies
- ▶ Writing supplies

OPTIONAL

- ▶ Scripture BLM 23
- ▶ Activity BLM 23
- ▶ Scripture Prayer Service BLM 23
- ▶ Construction paper, craft sticks, glue, scissors
- ▶ Note cards
- ▶ Assessment: Session 23 www.findinggod.com

Living as God's Children

 SESSION
23


GOD'S WORD

Read and listen to
Luke 2:41–52.



Finding of the Child Jesus in the Temple, Simon Bening, circa 1530, Flanders, Belgium

Even at the age of 12, Jesus wanted to be with God, his Father. Once, he felt so at home in the Temple in Jerusalem that he forgot to go home with his parents. When they found that Jesus had stayed at the Temple instead of returning to Nazareth with them, they became upset. Even though he was God's son, Jesus was still their child to care for, and he needed to obey them. He still needed Mary and Joseph to be safe.

As wise as Jesus was, he still knew he had the responsibility to honor his parents. After Joseph and Mary came back for Jesus, he was obedient to them. We may want to go out on our own sometimes, but we must remember we are part of a loving family that cares for us. Like Jesus, we can recognize that and do as our parents ask.



Prayer

Jesus, teach me to appreciate the safety and support I receive from my family.

UNDERSTANDING SCRIPTURE

This story of the 12-year-old Jesus in the Temple is the only account of his childhood in the Gospels. The need he felt to be in his "Father's house" shows that he knew he was the Son of God the Father. Even at 12, Jesus was knowledgeably discussing Scripture with Jewish elders. At the same time, because he loved and obeyed Mary and Joseph, he went back home with them to live and grow with his human family.

IF TIME ALLOWS

Scripture BLM: Luke 2:41–52

Have children complete Scripture BLM 23 to gain a better understanding of the passage.



SESSION 23

OUTCOMES

- Explain how Jesus obeyed his parents.
- Recognize that the Holy Spirit helps us live in peace.
- Identify Saint Louise de Marillac as someone who served others.
- Describe how Saint Paul spread joy and love to his Church family.
- ▶ Define *justice*.

1 Open Your Heart

Invite children to quiet themselves and prepare to hear sacred Scripture.

2 Proclaim God's Word

Take the Bible from the Prayer Center. Read Luke 2:41–52. Then say: **The Gospel of the Lord.** Invite children to respond *Praise to you, Lord Jesus Christ.*

3 The Word Alive

Ask: **When you are at your best, how do you interact with your parents?** (do what they ask without complaining)
Say: **When we do what our parents ask, we honor them. What does this mean?** (to recognize and accept their authority)
Read the paragraphs. Ask: **How did Jesus honor Joseph and Mary?** (He obeyed them.)



Prayer

Say: **Let's pray that we will always share joy with our families and with other people. Pray the prayer with me.** Conclude the prayer by praying *Amen.*



If appropriate and feasible, have children scan the code on page 189.

1 Begin

Show children a greeting card. Ask: **Why might you give or send someone a card?** (to let them know you are thinking of them on a holiday or special occasion; to thank them)

2 Connect

Write *domestic church* on the board. Have a child read aloud the heading and the first paragraph. Say: **Each of our families is a community called a "domestic church."** Have children look up the word *justice* in the Glossary. Ask: **How does justice help bring about peace and harmony in our families?** (Justice is respecting others and valuing their dignity. Acting justly fosters harmony.)

Have a volunteer read aloud the second paragraph. Ask children to think about other people they could help in addition to their families, such as their parish family and friends.

ACTIVITY Read aloud the activity A Thank-You Card. Give children time to think about what they will write. Then have them complete the activity.

? Did You Know?

Actual graces are instances of grace we receive that help us in our daily lives. Actual graces guide family members to treat one another with justice—to treat one another fairly.

3 Close

Ask: **What are some ways you have experienced the domestic church in your home?** (Answers could include praying before family meals, helping siblings, saying thank you.)

The Domestic Church

God calls us to care for one another. We start at home with our family. The family is a "domestic church," a community open to the graces of the Holy Spirit. The actual graces we receive from the Holy Spirit help us live together in peace, harmony, and justice. We treat our family and others with justice by treating them fairly. We obey and respect our parents, as Jesus did.

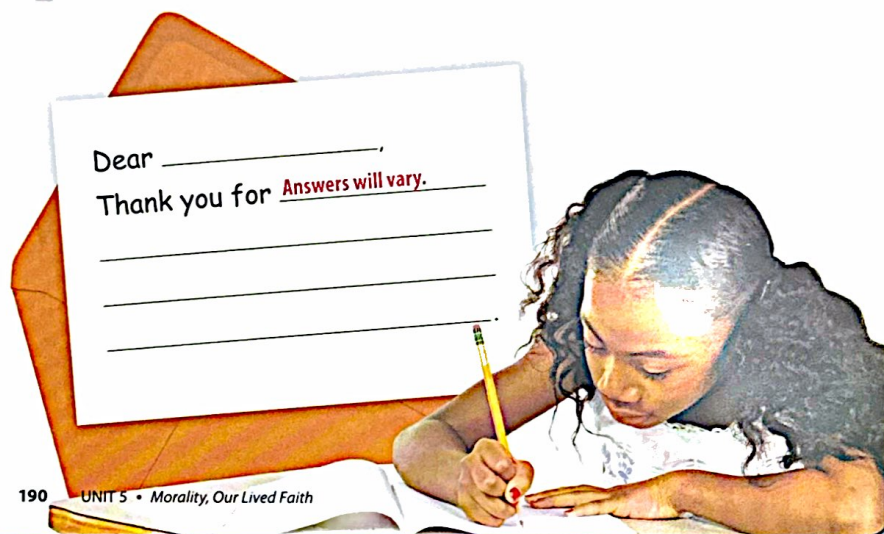
We can share the Spirit's love with one another by helping the members of our family. We can also help those who cannot help themselves.

? Did You Know?

Actual graces are those we receive every day to help us follow God's call to care for him and one another.

ACTIVITY: A Thank-You Card

We can tell our families how blessed we are to have them. Think of reasons you are thankful to belong to your family. Complete the card. Tell a family member what he or she does that makes you feel thankful.



190 UNIT 5 • Morality, Our Lived Faith

IF TIME ALLOWS

Activity BLM: Complete the Story

Have children complete Activity BLM 23 to review what they know about Saint Louise de Marillac and Saint Vincent de Paul.



WATCH a video about the domestic Church.



INCLUSION

Gifted

Have children who could benefit from a more complex activity research a modern-day saint or blessed who worked for peace and justice. Invite children to write and share a short paragraph, poem, or slideshow presentation about that person.

Saint Louise de Marillac

Louise de Marillac lived in France during the 17th century. When her husband died, she devoted her life to God. She began by visiting people who lacked resources and giving them clothes she had sewn and knitted. She met Vincent de Paul. She helped him care for people who were poor or sick.

Louise and Vincent together formed an order of women, the Daughters of Charity. They were devoted to directly serving people in need. That means that the Daughters of Charity spent their days working in villages, homes, orphanages, hospitals, and schools. In North America, the Sisters of Charity of Saint Vincent de Paul arose out of the work of the Daughters of Charity. They continue to serve people in need all over the world. March 15 is the feast of Saint Louise de Marillac.



Saint Louise de Marillac,
by Robert Lentz



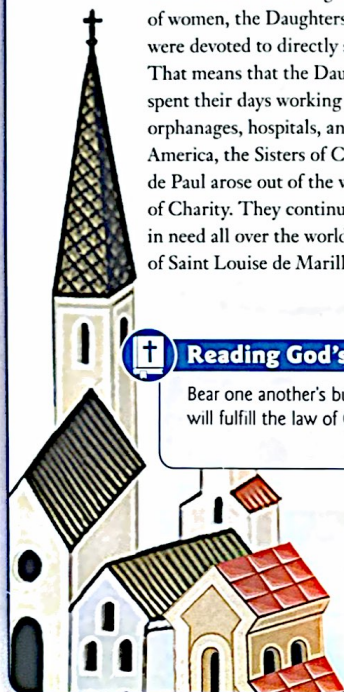
Saint Vincent de Paul,
by Robert Lentz



Reading God's Word

Bear one another's burdens, and so you will fulfill the law of Christ.

Galatians 6:2



SESSION 23 • Living as God's Children 191

IF TIME ALLOWS

Service: Support Those Who Serve

Point out to children that Catholic Charities does work similar to that which Louise and Vincent did in their lives. Go to catholiccharitiesusa.org/our-ministry and explore with children some of the organization's activities. With permission from your catechetical director, host a bake and crafts sale. Have children contribute as their families' means permit. All the goods or crafts sold should be made by the children and/or their families. Donate the money raised to Catholic Charities.



Life and Dignity

1 Begin

Read the heading and point to the two pictures. Ask: **Based on the pictures, what kind of lives do you think Louise de Marillac and Vincent de Paul led?** (They lived holy lives and cared for people in need.)

2 Connect

Ask a volunteer to read aloud the first paragraph. Ask: **How did Louise devote her life to God?** (She made clothes for people who lacked resources.) **Whom did she meet and help?** (Saint Vincent de Paul)

Read aloud the second paragraph. Ask: **How did the Sisters of Charity come to be?** (Vincent de Paul put Louise in charge of a new order of women.) Ask: **What do the Sisters of Charity of Saint Vincent de Paul do?** (They work in orphanages, hospitals, and schools.) Say: **Louise de Marillac is an example of how our efforts bring God's love to many people.**



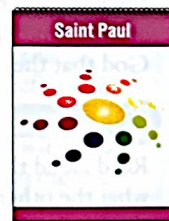
The Poor and Vulnerable

Reading God's Word

Read aloud the passage. Ask: **What does it mean to "bear one another's burdens"?** (to help one another with our difficulties)

3 Close

Use the following page and the Art Print easel to teach Art Print 23: *Saint Paul*.



1 Begin

Display the Art Print easel open to Art Print 23. Briefly introduce and discuss the artwork, using information from About the Artist and Art•i•facts. Ask: **Why do you think stained-glass windows often appear in churches?** (They depict scenes from the Bible.) **What is around Saint Paul's head?** (halo) Say: **A halo symbolizes God's grace. Its circular shape is a symbol of eternity, which has no beginning and no end.**

2 Connect

Have children turn to page 192 in their books. Read aloud the introduction and discuss the question.

Invite a volunteer to read aloud Saint Paul's Joy. Ask: **What gave Paul joy?** (knowing that his friends were growing in their faith) Say: **Paul stayed close to his church family by visiting and writing to them.** Tell children you will read them part of a letter from Paul to friends in Philippi, Greece. Then read aloud the passage.

ACTIVITY Read aloud the questions below the letter and give children time to respond.

3 Close

Invite children to reflect on the artwork and pray silently, thanking God that they are part of his family.

Link to Liturgy

Read aloud this feature. Ask children what the other two readings in the Liturgy of the Word are. (Old Testament, a Gospel reading)

Art Print 23 shows Saint Paul in bright, happy colors. Paul was happy that people were growing in their faith. How do you feel when you think of God's love?

Saint Paul's Joy

We are joyful when our family is happy and peaceful. Saint Paul was excited when he heard how some of his friends were growing in their faith. He knew that the more they grew in the love of Jesus Christ, the more they would serve others. He wrote his friends a letter telling them how much he loved them.

I give thanks to my God at every remembrance of you, praying always with joy in my every prayer for all of you. I am confident . . . that the one who began a good work in you will continue to complete it. And this is my prayer: that your love may increase ever more and more in knowledge and every kind of perception, to discern what is of value. *Philippians 1:3-6,9-10*

ACTIVITY: Thank You!

Would you like to receive a letter like this? Which words in the letter would make you happy? Answers will vary.



Link to Liturgy

The second reading during the Liturgy of the Word in Sunday Mass is often from one of Paul's letters.

IF TIME ALLOWS

Art Studio: Stained Glass

Provide children with a cross cut from construction paper. In advance, cut out a two-inch piece from the center, allowing the paper to serve as the lead for a stained-glass window. Ask children to cut and tape colored cellophane behind the cross, making a stained-glass picture to hang in their windows at home.



Using the Art Print

For additional activities and prayer opportunities, see the Art Print back.

REFLECT

Choose an approach for prayer.

APPROACH 1

Recorded Guided Reflection 

Prepare Listen in advance to the recorded guided reflection "Hold Them in Your Heart." Decide if

you will use the recording or lead the reflection yourself. If you choose to lead, listen to the recording a second time, following the script on pages T-316–T-317 and noting pauses and tone. You can use the script or adapt it as you wish.



Prayer

During the session, play the recording or lead using the script, joining children in reflective prayer. If you use the script, play reflective music softly in the background.

APPROACH 2

Children's Prayer

Prepare Read the prayer in advance to become familiar with it.



Prayer

Say: *We are going to reflect on Paul's letter to his church family and on how we can show love to our own families.*

Say: *Find a comfortable position.* Pause while children do this. Read aloud the paragraph above the reflection. Then read the reflection, pausing between sentences. Then say: *Now spend a quiet moment with Jesus.* Pause. Lead children in praying the Sign of the Cross.

A Prayer for Family Members

In his letters, Saint Paul told the people in different communities that he prayed for them. In the quiet of your heart, pray the imaginative prayer below.

REFLECT



Prayer

Think of Paul's letter to his friends. He prays for them and holds them in his heart. Close your eyes and picture the members of your family for a moment. Thank God for the guidance in faith and prayer you have received from your family.

Now spend a few minutes talking with Jesus. Tell him the good things you enjoy in your family and parish. Ask Jesus to guide you in showing love to your family and to others. Tell how you will try especially to help those who cannot help themselves.

Be still and thank Jesus for being with you. Ask Jesus to bless you and everyone in your family and in your parish.



SESSION 23 • Living as God's Children 193

IF TIME ALLOWS

Scripture Prayer Service BLM:

Luke 2:41–52

For an optional Prayer Service focused on this session's opening Scripture passage, refer to Scripture Prayer Service BLM 23.



COACHING CHILDREN TO PRAY

As they pray the reflection, invite children to think of the Fourth Commandment: "Honor your father and your mother, that you may have a long life in the land the LORD your God is giving you." [Exodus 20:12] Also encourage children to remember that Jesus was born into a human family. Invite children to think about how they grow in appreciation for their families.



If appropriate and feasible, have children scan the code on page 193.

REFLECT

1 Begin

Discuss the fun of riding a bike. Ask: ***If you own a bike, have you ever had a problem with it?*** Discuss children's answers, which might include flat tires or loose chains. Say: ***When one part of a bike doesn't work, the bike doesn't work. For you to be able to ride the bike, all the parts must work. That's how it is with families too. When all the parts work, the family is peaceful. When our families are peaceful, we enjoy being together.***

2 Connect

Read aloud the heading and paragraph. Ask: ***Have you and your family members ever worked together to do something around your home? What kind of job did you do together?*** (Possible answers: raked leaves; cooked dinner; made beds; fixed a broken piece of furniture) Say: ***When we work together with family members, we help bring peace to our families.***

ACTIVITY Read aloud the directions for How We Help One Another. Allow time for children to think about the stories and write their answers. When children have finished, give them an opportunity to share their responses.

3 Close

Say: ***Let's take a moment to reflect on our own families and how we treat one another.*** Pause. ***Now take a moment to thank God for your families.*** Pause. Then pray aloud *Amen*.

REFLECT

Family Cooperation

Family members show one another they care. We can support our family in many ways. We can share in family work. We can help brothers and sisters with problems. We can pray together as a family. With the grace of the Holy Spirit, our family members live together in peace and joy.

ACTIVITY: How We Help One Another

In each instance below, write what you can do to help a member of your family.



1. Your parents are hosting a gathering. How can you help?
help clean and straighten up;
put out food and set the table
2. Your grandmother, who lives with you, is sitting alone at the table. What might you do?
sit with her and ask her how her day has been
3. You and your sibling both want to use the basketball at the same time. How do you work out this problem?
play together or arrange a time to switch
4. Your family is busy but would like to set up a prayer time. How can you help?
go around and ask each family member when would be a good time for him or her, then report back to the group

194 UNIT 5 • Morality, Our Lived Faith

IF TIME ALLOWS

Props for the Stories

 Have children use construction paper and craft sticks to make an object to illustrate one of the scenarios in the activity on page 194. They could make a bowl of food, a place setting, a pair of glasses, a basketball, or a prayer schedule. Have children glue their props to craft sticks to hold up as they read the scenarios they have chosen.

Living My Faith

Faith Summary

With the help of the Holy Spirit, we can live in peace, harmony, and justice with others. Obeying and respecting your parents is a way to create harmony in your family. Saint Louise de Marillac provides an example of caring for others. She founded the Daughters of Charity to help people who lacked what they needed to live.

Word I Learned

justice

Ways of Being Like Jesus

We can share God's love by helping others. *Offer to do a chore, such as shoveling snow or raking leaves, for someone who needs your help.*

ACTIVITY: Helping and Being Cared For

As we grow, we learn to do more things for ourselves. We also can show thanks for the things provided by those who care for us. Fill in the chart with things you can do to help and ways in which your parents care for you. An example is provided.

Ways I Can Help	Ways I Need My Parents
set the table	be there so I feel safe

Prayer

Jesus, help me be as loving to my family members as you were to your family and as you are to the Father's family.

SESSION 23 • Living as God's Children

195

1 Begin

Faith Summary Invite a volunteer to read aloud this section. Ask: **How can we share God's love?** (by caring for others) **How can we show peace in our families?** (by obeying and respecting our parents)

2 Connect

Word I Learned Invite children to read the Glossary definition of *justice*. Ask volunteers to use *justice* in two sentences, one about their families and another about their friends.

Ways of Being Like Jesus Ask a volunteer to read aloud this section. Invite children to think of more examples of how they can share God's love by helping someone in need, such as reading to someone who is visually impaired.

ACTIVITY Read aloud the introduction and directions. Ask children to share their responses with the class.

Prayer

Say: **Let's ask Jesus to help us be good to our family members, as he was good to his.** Pray slowly with children. Conclude by praying *Amen*.

IF TIME ALLOWS



ACCESS an Interactive Session Review.



Cooperation Station

Set up four stations in the room. At each, place a note card with a question written on it, such as *Why are community helpers so important?* Place children in four groups and have them assign the roles of question reader, answer recorder, and timekeeper to three of the members. Give each group paper and a pencil. Rotate groups through the stations as they develop their answers at each one.

3 Go in Peace

Invite children to share this tear-out page with their families. To close this session, say: ***This week show your family and friends how much you love them. Be understanding and considerate like Jesus as you work and play with them.***

With My Family

Scripture Together

Honoring and obeying our parents is the Fourth Commandment. When we honor our parents and other caregivers, we honor God the Father.

As a family, read about parents and children in Sirach 3:1-7. When you have finished, discuss the Scripture. Use the questions below to guide you:

- How does God the Father want people to treat their mothers and fathers?
- How does following your parents' rules help keep you safe?
- What can you say and do to honor your family members?

Family Prayer

Pray together:
Dear God, help us as a family to be understanding and forgiving of one another. Amen.

Faith on the Go

Ask one another: *When you have differences, what is a good way to try to work them out?*

ACTIVITY: Notes of Appreciation

Have each family member write on a sticky note a message about a kindness a parent or sibling did for them. Have each person post his or her note in the house where the recipient can find it.



196 UNIT 5 • Morality, Our Lives

ASSESSMENT

Session Assessment Option

A session assessment can be found at www.findinggod.com.

PLAN AHEAD: Get Ready for Session 24

Consult the catechist preparation pages to prepare for Session 24 and determine any materials you will need.